12.11 Scaling capacity and pricing

As discussed at the beginning of the chapter, the difference between a typical relational database and a NoSQL database is that a NoSQL database can be scaled by adding new nodes. Horizontal scaling enables increasing the read and write capacity of a database enormously. That's the case for DynamoDB as well. However, a DynamoDB table has two different read/write capacity modes:

- *On-demand mode* adapts the read and write capacity automatically.
- *Provisioned mode* requires you to configure the read and write capacity upfront. Additionally, you have the option to enable autoscaling to adapt the provisioned capacity based on the current load automatically.

At first glance, the first option sounds much better because it is totally maintenance free. Table 12.1 compares the costs between on-demand and provisioned modes. All of the following examples are based on costs for `us-east-1` and assume you are reading and writing items with less than 1 KB.

Table 12.1 Comparing pricing of DynamoDB on-demand and provisioned mode

Throughput	On-demand mode	Provisioned mode
10 writes per second	$32.85 per month	$4.68 per month
100 reads per second	$32.85 per month	$4.68 per month

That's a significant difference. Accessing an on-demand table costs about seven times as much as using a table in provisioned capacity